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**r/audioengineering** • 1y ago
dante4life

# Is there an industry standard DAW for making sci-fi sound effects?

I currently use Reaper for everything music in my videos. If I wanted sound effects, I just get stock sounds then throw it in Reaper as well. I figure I would eventually need to learn abount synthesizer plugins if I wanted to go pro. By sci-fi sounds, I mean laser gun, lightsaber whooshes, dinosaur roars, etc.. Is there a preferred DAW for this in the industry?

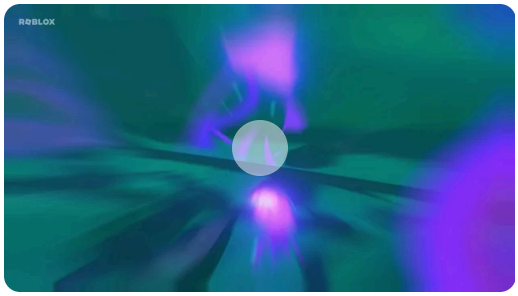
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**yourdadsboyfie** • 1y ago
a DAW choice is more for the user/creator than it is for the final product/listener. use the DAW you vibe with best and you can make anything.

19

**CumulativeDrek2** • 1y ago
You'd probably be better off just learning about different kinds of synthesis techniques and some foundational acoustics to start with. A DAW is not really a critical factor in procedural/synthetic sound design work.

A really good book on the subject is Designing Sound by Andy Farnell.

4

**AxIndo** • 1y ago
A industry specific standard DAW for just making effects? Not entirely, no. I'd say the easiest would be Logic or Ableton, but you'll of course get people saying Pro Tools even though I still don't find MIDI work on there amazing. This will just come down to what plugins/wavetable/serums you have and how comfortable you are in whatever DAW you use to just start making sounds as efficient as possible.

7

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for processing sounds. Spectral time, resonator, and corpus are better than any 3rd party plugin I've used for sound design.

3

**Icy_Jackfruit9240** • 1y ago

For film sound work, things have gotten complicated, but yeah Pro Tools probably is still the #1 choice. At least from the people I know in the industry, wavetable synthesis is popular for sound FX creation outside of the traditionally made and recorded stuff (still EXTREMELY common for many FX.) Also there's a lot of recycled sound FX. Vital is probably the #1 choice there, but that's a guess. (I imagine that A.D.D. is probably very popular.)

Now of course that type of sound work is separate from sound tracks which are generally whatever the person who's making it likes to use.

All that said, I don't believe there's any reason in 2025 for you to care what is used, but I think Pro Tools is still the most common choice.

2

**xylvnking** • 1y ago

reaper, ableton, bitwig are the most popular I see in sound design, so you're good to go with reaper. More important which instrument/synth, which for sound design I'd recommend phase plant as it has unlimited everything which comes in handy for complex sci-fi sounds, and the companies subscription model is rent-to-own.

2

**rinio** • 1y ago

Once we're at 'industry level', almost all work will be relying on third party plug-ins heavily. The cost is no longer material as its a business expense/tax write-off.

This makes the choice of DAW, pretty irrelevant. The stock plug-ins are easily replaced against 3p options and the DAW license itself is also a business expense as well so cost is immaterial. (Partly why DAW prices are still high; enterprise/commercial users don't care).

So the choice comes down to whether the enterprise has a pipeline built on a specific DAW, which would dictate what to use for certain tasks. But, since we can always pipe audio into that DAW, we could do sound design in any DAW.

So, ultimately, its just a question of user preference. It really doesn't matter and 'Sci Fi SFX' is no different than any other application.

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In the film post world, there is no question that Pro Tools is the market leader by a very wide margin. But, sound designers, folk doing Foley, etc, may be using other DAWs to make their base sounds.

Similarly, Reaper is popular in the games industry as its the most amenable for building pipelines at scale. IE: when you need to efficiently and automatically render 10000+ audio assets. But, again designer may use other DAWs as a base.

Music has a wider variety of DAWs being used at 'industry level' and is the perspective of most users of this sub. I won't dive in since you're its unclear if you're asking about music or film and you'll already get an abundance of answers from that perspective.

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TLDR: The best DAW is the one *you* work most efficiently in. The choice doesn't really matter unless you have a specific workflow/feature for your needs.

2

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**notoriouseyelash** • 1y ago

look into how sound effects were produced before the digital era. maybe not the most practical solutions these days but itll really open your mind to how little you need a dedicated tool designed for them.

to actually answer your question, any daw will work. you'll mainly be looking at plugins if youre looking to do digital sound design - anything will work but i know glitchmachines makes some audio effects/synthesizers that are both affordable and geared towards some of the territory youre looking for

2

**Flatliner0452** • 1y ago

Look up some studios you would want to work for and ask them what DAW they use.

Reaper is exceptionally popular in games for sound design because of all the scripts you can write for batch editing things.

1

**peepeeland** • 1y ago

No, there is no standard DAW for sci-fi sound effects. There are a lot of tools used.

BTW- research how the original lightsaber sounds were made— it's pretty cool. Laser gun sounds can be done with almost any synth. Dinosaur roars- research how they did them for the original Jurassic Park.

In short- some sounds effects are synth based, but some are sample mangling and layering.

1

**TinyXPR** • 1y ago

It is so different and futuristic, that it might be exactly what you're looking for.

1

**alijamieson** • 1y ago

Reaper is pretty much the go-to for many SFX designers, as I'm sure you know. For film and TV Pro Tools is still the standard

1

**Babosmarach666** • 1y ago

**j3434** • 1y ago

No they all have drag and drop sound libraries. And you can sample sounds and tweak them like Forbidden Planet or Marooned (70s)

1

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**HugePines** • 1y ago

I've done a lot of sound design (especially sci fi) for audio dramas. Reaper is excellent. Build an fx library and keep it organized. Good sound design usually blends multiple samples and effects. The media browser (ctrl-alt-x) is your friend. The stock plugins will do everything you need.

The most important part is learning the fundamentals of mixing and synthesis which is easier in whichever DAW you know best.

1

**ezeequalsmchammer2** • 1y ago

For what it's worth, reaper. Pro tools is often the standard but many SFX people use reaper.

1

**milotrain** • 1y ago

If you are actually talking about industry (as in TV and Film) standard for sound effects, sci-fi and otherwise, then the only answer is ProTools.

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**GrandmasterPotato** • 1y ago

I know you do t want to hear this but I didn't really start to learn synthesis before I bought a synth. Prophet Rev2 to be exact. Has really helped me navigate many soft synths.

-1

**Dr--Prof** • 1y ago

Vital is free and great to learn synthesis and sound design.

2

**milotrain** • 1y ago

Same. I bought a B* 2600.

2

**Dr--Prof** • 1y ago

If you are looking for Sound Design, you're good with Reaper. Although not considered "industry standard" (a marketing jargon more than anything), it's the most used DAW in the Gaming industry. It has some cool add-ons to make your work easy.

If you want to learn Sound Design, the DAW is not that important if you use some plugins. Learn synthesis and sampling. Vital is a free and very popular synth. Kontakt is a widely known and very powerful sampler.

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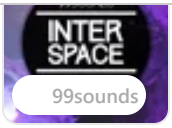
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